



UROS

PEOPLE OF THE WATER

AT THE PERUVIAN END OF LAKE TITICACA lie over 40 tiny masses called the Uros floating islands. Unlike ordinary islands, which are part of the Earth's surface, these are man-made from the hollow *tortora* reeds that thrive in the shallow waters of the lake. The lives of the Uros

Floating nests

The Uros islands look like huge straw nests floating in the bright blue waters of Lake Titicaca. Each one is formed from layer on layer of *tortora* reeds, woven by hand into mats and bound tightly together. The reeds rot very quickly, however, so new ones are constantly being added on top to renew the surface.



REED HOMES

Uros families live in huts made completely from *tortora* reeds. Wooden stakes support the bases, which are raised slightly off the ground. The walls and the roof are formed from sheets of bound reeds known as *quesana*. A few of these huts are equipped with solar panels as a power source.



1 Collecting

The reeds that the Uros people use are pulled away from the bottom of the lake by its moving waters. This woman is collecting them in her reed boat.



2 Drying

Before they can be woven, the long reeds are laid out to dry in the sun. This doesn't take long, since its strong rays are intensified by the lake's glassy surface.



3 Weaving

Here, reeds are bound into bundles that form one of the small, simple boats the Uros people use to transport themselves and their possessions.

WOVEN CURRENCY

Like many South American peoples, the Uros weave beautiful textiles. They sell these to the tourists and trade them on the mainland for clothing and household supplies.



TROUBLE UNDERFOOT

The Uros people are very used to walking on the spongy, uneven surface of their islands. Visitors and children, though, can easily fall through a weak patch. The ground is constantly being renewed, but accidents do happen.